it turned out, the last Indian Political Officer before Sikkim joined India). On the train, perhaps near Siliguri, I was in a compartment with Indian troops returning from Bangladesh. War is hell of course, and the soldiers were grey-faced. I was entering my last year at school. The officers were not much older than me. We got talking about the war, and one said, 'It is our problem now' – referring to Bangladesh. It was a sobering moment. A week later I would have another sobering moment, this time at the India–China border.

Gangtok to Nathu La is about sixty kilometres by road, about a two-hour journey. My elder brother and I, getting restless in the palatial residence of the Political Officer, were dispatched on a day trip to the pass. Nathu La is where India and China had fought a blood-filled battle in 1967, with hundreds of casualties. Along mountain switchbacks and climbs, we were nauseated and clutched ourselves against the cold. Gangtok is at an elevation of 1650 metres, but Nathu La is at three times that height. It is a fairly rapid climb to the pass, and for plainspeople the ascent can leave you breathless and slightly dizzy. Like most Indians, I had never been to a border area: borders were lines on a map I could draw by rote from my geography classes and not much else – shadow lines, to use novelist Amitav Ghosh's words. As we climbed, I was beginning to see what a border might really be, in the Himalaya at any rate. The first indications we were closing in on Nathu La were large signs painted on bare mountainsides warning us we were within various calibres of gunfire. The last sign, as the army jeep slowed, said: 'You are now within small arms fire.'

At Nathu La, after some bread dipped in sweet black tea, we were led out towards a post. It was not far, as I recall. The scene was bleak: it was windy and grey, and I think there were a few huts and trenches. At some point, as we perhaps showed disappointment at standing around the post and looking across at China, a young officer pointed to movement on the other side and handed us binoculars. When my eyes got used to the binoculars, I found myself looking at a gaunt Chinese soldier in an overcoat, stamping his foot and hugging himself against the cold. He was smoking a cigarette. All of a sudden, he saw me looking at him and